

Session 27: Jacob's Burial

Key Takeaways

- Yoseph goes up to Canaan, which contrasts with his going down to Egypt, highlighting the hope of a return to Eden threaded throughout the story of Genesis.
- The Egyptians embalm and mourn for Yaaqov, united with Yoseph's family in grief, showing how the blessed family of Abraham is sown among the nations.
- Yoseph imitates God as he comforts his brothers with the gift of reconciliation, demonstrating trust in God's faithfulness.
- In Genesis 50:19-21, Yoseph summarizes themes from the entire book of Genesis regarding God's plan to bring good out of evil and provide comfort to a world suffering under the consequences of sin.

Paragraph 2: Genesis 50:1-11

¹ And Yoseph fell upon the face of his father,
and he **wept** over him,
and he kissed him.

² And Yoseph commanded his servants **the healers (הרפאים)** to **embalm** his father,
and **the healers (הרפאים)** **embalmed** Yisra'el.

³ And they fulfilled for him **forty days**,
because this is how the days of the **embalmers** were fulfilled.
Then **Egypt** **wept** for him for **seventy days**.

A ⁴ And the days of **weeping** for him passed on,
and Yoseph said to the house of Phar'oh, saying,

"If, **please**, I have found favor in your eyes,
speak, **please**, in to ears of Phar'oh, saying,

⁵ 'My father made me **swear an oath**, saying,
"Look, I am about to die.

B In my **burial-grave** which I dug for myself in the land of Cana'an,
bury me there."

'And now, **may I go up**, **please**,
so I can **bury** my father,

and so I can return.”

⁶ And Phar’oh said,

A’ “Go up and bury your father,
just as he made you swear an oath.”

⁷ And Yoseph went up to bury his father,
and they went up with him,

a all the servants of Phar’oh,

b the elders of his house,

a’ and all the elders of the land of Egypt,

a ⁸ and all the house of Yoseph,

b and his brothers,

a’ and the house of his father.

Only their children and their flocks and their herds did they leave in the land of Goshen.

⁹ And they went up with him, both chariots and horsemen,
and the camp was heavy, very much.

¹⁰ And they came to the threshing floor of the thorn (= Goren-Ha’atad),
and they wept there a great and heavy weeping, very much,
and they performed grieving for their father, for seven days.

¹¹ And the inhabitant of the land, the Cana’anite, saw the grieving at the threshing floor of the thorn,
and they said,

“This is a heavy grieving for Egypt!”

For this reason, its name is called,

“Grief of Egypt” [= “Avel-Mitsrayim”]
which is across the Jordan.

Genesis 50:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This central paragraph in 50:1-11 consists of three parts.

- A pair of matching outer sections that focus on the grief and weeping that took place at Yaaqov’s death (Gen. 50:1-3) and at his entry into the promised land (Gen. 50:10-11). Notice that both take place in matching periods of time that consists of a multiple of seven (70 days // 7 days).
- A pair of matching central sections that focus on Yoseph’s request for the burial procession (Gen. 50:4-6) and then on the narrative fulfillment of those requests (Gen. 50:7-9). The central unifying themes of these center units is the request to “go up” and “bury.”

Mummies and the Hope of the Afterlife

Egyptian mummies are well-known in our culture as a famous icon of ancient Near Eastern burial practices. In the final chapter of the Genesis scroll, which began with a story about humans losing access to eternal life, it

is no accident that we find ourselves focused on a contrast between Yaaqov's hope in the resurrection and the hope of the afterlife in Egyptian culture.

"It is well known that mummification, with all its elaborate ritual, played a crucial role in the Egyptian religion and was bound up with the cult of Osiris and conceptions of the afterlife. Survival of death was taken for granted by the Egyptians. Central to this notion was the belief in the importance of the physical preservation of the body. They took meticulous care to prevent the putrefaction of the corpse in order to ensure the right of the deceased to immortality. But the embalming of Jacob and Joseph is without any religious significance. In both cases the act is a purely practical measure, for Jacob is to be buried far from his place of death, and Joseph is to be reinterred many years later (v. 25). The text subtly underlines the disconnection of the embalming procedure from any pagan context by having Joseph entrust the task to 'physicians in his service.' It was not performed by professional mortuary priests. ... Detailed information on the embalming process is lacking for the ancient period, but is available from the 5th century B.C.E. and from the late Hellenistic period. Herodotus (Histories 2.86) reports that the body was placed in niter for seventy days. Diodorus of Sicily (Histories 1.91) describes a thirty-day dressing of the corpse with oils and spices and seventy-two days of public mourning for a king. Jacob is apparently being accorded royal honors."

Sarna, Nahum M. (2001). [*Genesis, The JPS Torah Commentary*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 347.

The Garden-Thorn Place

Notice how the outer sections both feature non-Israelites who participate in the mourning rituals or observe the intensity of grief.

- The scene in [Genesis 50:1-3](#) shows the Egyptians honoring Yaaqov with ritual mourning ("they wept") and with embalming, a custom that would ensure safe and honorable passage into the after life.
- The scene in [Genesis 50:10-11](#) takes place right after the procession crosses into the land of Canaan. Here, it's the Canaanites who observe the intensity of grief taking place among the Egyptians.

Notice the echoes of Eden in this story.

- Yaaqov dies (linking back to the exile from Eden and return to the dust).
- They stop at the "threshing floor of the thorn."
 - In Hebrew, "threshing floor" is *goren* (גרן), spelled with its first and last letters identical with the Hebrew word for "garden" (*gan* / גן).
 - The word "thorn" evokes the curse upon the ground from [Genesis 3:17-19](#), where the land of Adam and Eve's exile will become a land of "thorns and thistles."
- This short scene portrays Yaaqov's return to the Eden land promised to Yaaqov as a tragedy. The entire story so far creates a desire for humanity's return to Eden. And here is Yahweh's chosen one, finally returning after a long exile in Egypt, and he comes to the "Garden-Thorn" place deceased and unable to enjoy the blessings of Eden.
- Notice how the theme of "embalming" and "burial" highlights the ideas of the afterlife as Yaaqov is buried with his ancestors. While there is some comfort knowing that Yaaqov will be reunited with his ancestors upon his death, we are also at the same time disheartened. The hope was for the blessings of Eden to spread outside the garden, and all we have near the end of the Genesis scroll is a dead man returning to an Eden-like place at Makpelah.

Yoseph Reconciles With His Brothers

¹⁵ And the brothers of Yoseph saw that **their father was dead**, and they said,

“Surely, Yoseph will become one who opposes us, and he will certainly return to us all **the evil we repaid him**.”

¹⁶ And they commanded Yoseph, saying,

“**Your father** commanded **before his death**, saying,

¹⁷ ‘This is what you will say to Yoseph,

“Please **forgive the betrayal of your brothers**, and their failure, because of **the evil they repaid you**.””

So now, please **forgive the betrayal of the servants** of the **Elohim** of your fathers!”

And Yoseph wept as they spoke to him.

¹⁸ And also his brothers went and they fell before him and said,

“Look, we are **your servants**!”

¹⁹ And Yoseph said to them,

“**Do not be afraid**!

^a Indeed, am I in the place of Elohim?!

²⁰ As for you all, **you planned evil against me**.

^b **Elohim, he planned it for good**,

in order to accomplish what happened this day, **to preserve the lives** of a great many people.

^{a'} ²¹ So now, **do not be afraid**!

I will support you all and your children.”

And he brought them comfort,

and he spoke to their heart.

Genesis 50:15-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The Satan, Esau, ... and Yoseph?

Yoseph's brothers are afraid Yoseph will enact vengeance on them now that their father is dead. Their speech cleverly activates the narrative pattern of sibling rivalry that began back in Genesis 3 and was carried forward through the pattern of Cain and Abel, as well as Yaaqov and Esau.

The brothers' speech among themselves uses the same rare word that was used of Esau's murderous anger against Yaaqov.

Perhaps he will hold become opposed to us (שטם) and repay us for all the evil we did to him.

Genesis 27:41 Instructor's Translation

And Esau **became opposed** (שטם) against Yaaqov for the blessing with which his father blessed him.

Additionally, this rare verb “satam” (שטם) is the verbal form of the Hebrew root “satan” (שטן), “to be opposed to, hostile against.” This scene links together all of the hostile siblings in Genesis and connects back to the original firstborn who became hostile to God’s younger chosen one: the humans on day six of creation.

The Reconciliation of the Family

The reconciliation of the brothers is a crucial theme in this scene.

“Abraham had two sons but they did not get on together. Isaac had two sons, but they parted forever. Not until Jacob’s twelve sons was the future firmly established. But precisely because they were a large number was there a danger of disunity and division. In the event there was dissension among them, so that they hated and persecuted the best of them. But eventually there was a complete reconciliation, not through the arbitration of a third party, but through the inner transformation of those who hated, for which the sufferer had waited and now in brotherly love acknowledges.”

Jacob, Benno (1974). [The Book of Genesis](#). Ktav Publishing House. 942.

In appealing to Yoseph for forgiveness, the brothers once again fulfill his dreams and activate the entire pattern of the older son serving the younger son.

Gen. 50:18 “And his brothers came and they **fell before him** and they said, ‘**Behold, we are your slaves** (עבד)”

Gen. 37:10 “Will I, your mother, and your brothers **bow down to you on the ground** ?”

Gen. 44:10 “Whoever is found to have your cup, he will die and **we will be your slaves** (עבד)”

Gen. 27:29 “May you be mighty for your brothers, and **your mothers sons will bow down to you** ”

Gen. 25:23 “Two nations are in your womb ... one people will be mightier than the other, **and the greater will serve** (עבד) the older.”

Genesis 50's Hyperlinks to Earlier Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph’s words to his brothers bring together all of the themes of the entire scroll up to this point. God keeps elevating surprising chosen ones to be the vehicle of his Eden-blessing to others. Humans, on the other hand,

keep twisting these Eden gifts toward self-advantage, hurting themselves and others in the process. Yoseph's summary is relevant not just for his brother's story, but for every generation of the Genesis scroll, which has been replaying the primal folly and evil of the first generations as told in [Genesis 1-6](#).

But God's purpose is to raise up a promised see who will endure through the hardships of life outside the garden, and whose surrender and suffering becomes a gateway of God's promise and Eden-blessing for others. Here we find an important forward hyperlink—Yoseph's "comfort" and "words for the heart" provide the poet of Isaiah 40 with the language to describe the return from Babylonian exile as a similar moment. What God's own people did for evil, Yahweh is able to counter and use to bring about something good.

Genesis 50:20-21

"You planned **evil** (רעה) against me, but God planned it for **good** (טבה), in order to do as on this day:

to save the lives (להחית) of **many people** (עם רב)." ...

"And he **comforted** **them** (נחם), **and he spoke to their heart** (דבר על לב)."

Genesis 1-11

Gen. 1-3 good (טוב) and **evil** (רע)

Gen. 6:5 "the heart of humanity was only **evil** (רעה) all the time"

Gen. 6:18-19 "and you will enter the ark ... and the animals ... **to save life** (להחית)"

Gen. 5:29 "He named him Noah for he said, 'This one will **comfort us** ...' (נחם)"

Isaiah 40:1

" **Comfort, comfort** (נחם) **my people** , **speak to the heart** (דבר על לב) **of Jerusalem** ."

Genesis 50's Hyperlinks to Earlier Narratives and Isaiah. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

"[Genesis 46-50](#) shows how Joseph relates to Genesis' larger story of creation and covenant. Covenantal ... themes emerge quite prominently in Joseph's story, but only after the reconciliation between Joseph and his brothers. This order is significant. Fraternal conflict has plagued the covenant family and endangered the seed promise as far back as Cain and Abel. Joseph's reconciliation with his brothers, however, triggers an advance in covenant history. ... In Joseph, God reverses the status quo of violence against the covenant line. The reconciliation of the family is a demonstration that God is reversing the curse, turning evil in on itself, and advancing his cause in the world."

Emadi, Samuel (2018). [Covenant, Typology, and the Story of Joseph](#). Tyndale Bulletin, Volume 69.1. 94.

Reflection Question

How do Yoseph's words and perspective in Genesis 50:19-21 relate to the themes in the rest of the book of Genesis?